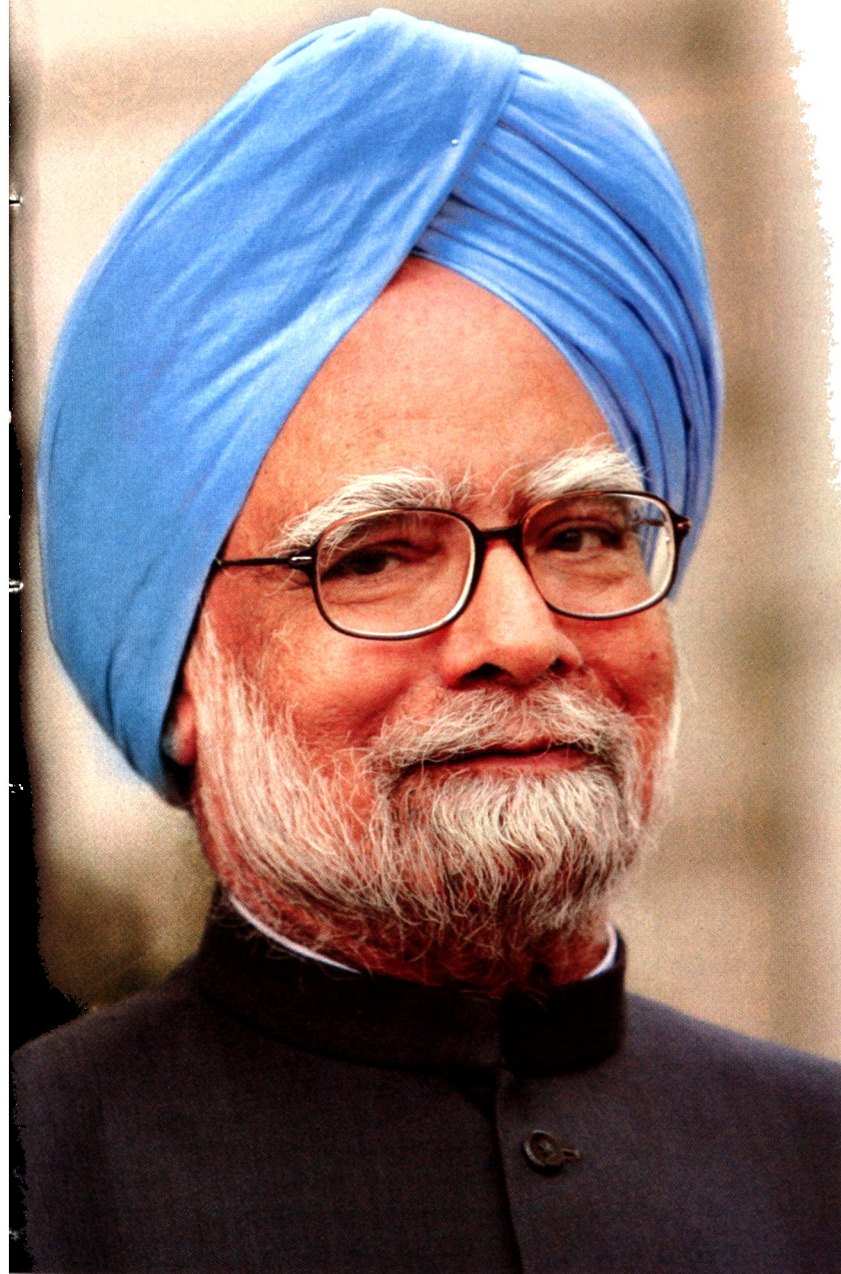




SURJIT HALDAR

## PERFORMANCE INDEX

A measure of how the Congress and BJP have fared in General Elections since 1989



**CONGRESS**



**BJP**

| YEAR | CONGRESS |     | BJP     |     |
|------|----------|-----|---------|-----|
|      | FIELDED  | WON | FIELDED | WON |
| 1989 | 510      | 197 | 226     | 86  |
| 1991 | 492      | 232 | 468     | 120 |
| 1996 | 490      | 140 | 438     | 161 |
| 1998 | 435      | 141 | 342     | 179 |
| 1999 | 452      | 114 | 347     | 182 |
| 2004 | 417      | 145 | 364     | 138 |
| 2009 | 473      | 206 | 427     | 116 |

Source: ECI, CLSA, Asia-Pacific Markets

Travelling across India, what is clear is that aspiration levels have changed forever. It needs to be reiterated that the media, mobile telephony and the roads development programme, particularly of the NDA government, have changed India forever. Access to information is fuelling aspirations and access to goods and services have helped in fulfilling them. The slogan of inclusive growth catches the imagination of the people—everyone wants to be on the gravy train. What people want is access to opportunities to fulfil their aspirations and not doles from the *mai baap sarkar*. Farmers want steady supply of power and not free power. The doles should be limited to the cross-section of the population below subsistence level since they need the helping hand of a welfare state.

On the political front, the verdict is one for stability—intended or unintended. It has been clear for a long time that for one party to once again come close to power on its own, the Hindi heartland will have to be won. This space was usurped by the regional parties, as they played the divide-and-rule game to electoral maths based on caste, sub-caste and religious considerations. The national parties joined the fray and have not been very different. While political empowerment was achieved, development was not, as is evident from the progress or the lack thereof in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. The Congress was forced to go alone in these states and it has proven to be a blessing in disguise.

What worked for the Congress was Rahul Gandhi's

**THE SLOGAN OF INCLUSIVE GROWTH CATCHES PEOPLE'S IMAGINATION AND EVERYONE WANTS TO BE ON THE GRAVY TRAIN. THEY WANT OPPORTUNITIES TO FULFIL THEIR ASPIRATIONS.**